



▲ VIKING RAIDERS

Vikings launched surprise attacks on coastal communities that had little or no way of defending themselves. They raided England and Francia (modern-day France) so often that these kingdoms started collecting a tax (later often called the danegeld) to pay off the Vikings and prevent them from stealing and destroying property.

LEIF ERIKSON

Around 1002, Viking explorer Leif Erikson (c.970–1020) reached what is now Newfoundland, Canada, and set up a settlement called Vinland there. He was probably the first European person to reach the Americas, arriving almost 500 years before Christopher Columbus.



The Vikings

A seafaring people, the Vikings originated in modern-day Sweden, Norway, and Denmark. They were known and feared across Europe for their violent raids (attacks), but they also traded peacefully with other lands. Between the 9th and 11th centuries, Vikings established trading outposts in the British Isles, mainland Europe, and even as far away as North America.

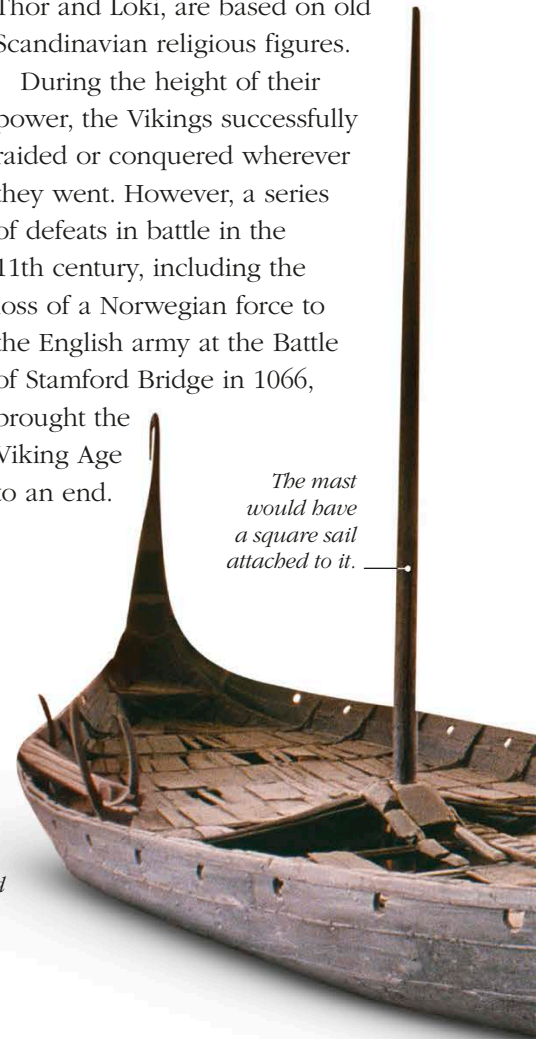
One of the earliest significant Viking raids was on Lindisfarne in England in 793. The Vikings went on to settle permanently in parts of England and Ireland, as well as Iceland and Greenland. They also penetrated deep into eastern Europe and set up a kingdom called the Kievan Rus', which gives Russia its modern name. As they settled, the Vikings began to trade, exchanging timber, iron, and furs for spices, salt, silk, and more. Around the end of the 10th century, they started minting their own coins.

Before Christianity became their main religion in the 11th century, the Vikings had their own religion with many deities. Their mythology is still influential in the modern

day—several film characters of the Marvel Universe, such as Thor and Loki, are based on old Scandinavian religious figures.

During the height of their power, the Vikings successfully raided or conquered wherever they went. However, a series of defeats in battle in the 11th century, including the loss of a Norwegian force to the English army at the Battle of Stamford Bridge in 1066, brought the Viking Age to an end.

The mast would have a square sail attached to it.



A spindle was used to twist wool into yarn (thread) for making clothes.



◀ VIKING WOMEN

Although Viking women did not enjoy the same status as men, they did have certain freedoms that were unusual for the time. They were allowed to own property and could also divorce their husbands in certain situations. While the men were away raiding, the women were in charge of making clothes and running the home and farms. Some women achieved significant power as members of noble or royal families, and in particular as queens.